

EYEWITNESS July 4, 1863

Surrender at Vicksburg

After two attacks on Vicksburg failed, General Grant used siege warfare to compel the city to surrender. From May 25, the inhabitants endured constant bombardment from Union positions around the city and from gun boats on the Mississippi. With supplies cut off and rations reduced, starvation began to take its toll until, on July 4, Confederate commander John Pemberton surrendered.

“Every day further progress was made in digging and mining, and at length a point was reached where the batteries could send their screaming shells directly to the heart of the city. A reign of terror took possession of the town, and its inhabitants dug themselves caves in the earth, seeking protection against the missiles of destruction which daily and nightly dropped in their midst. Such cannonading and shelling has perhaps scarcely been equaled. It was not safe from behind or before, and every part of the city was alike within range of the Federal guns ... For six weeks our batteries never ceased dropping their shot and shell on the doomed city. Food became scarce, and the inhabitants grew wan and thin in their narrow dens. At last, despairing of Johnston’s aid in raising the siege, and believing that Grant was ready for another assault on his works, they hung out the white flag in front of Gen. A. J. Smith’s Division.”

FROM THE *HISTORY OF THE 48TH OHIO VETERAN VOLUNTEER INFANTRY* BY MAJOR JOHN A. BERING AND CAPTAIN THOMAS MONTGOMERY, PUBLISHED 1880

“How sad was the spectacle that met our gaze: arms stacked in the center of the streets, men with tearful eyes and downcast faces walking here and there; men sitting in groups feeling that they would gladly have given their life-blood on the battlefield rather than hand over the guns and sabers so dear to them! ... Men looked so forlorn, some without shoes, some with tattered garments, yet they would have fought on.